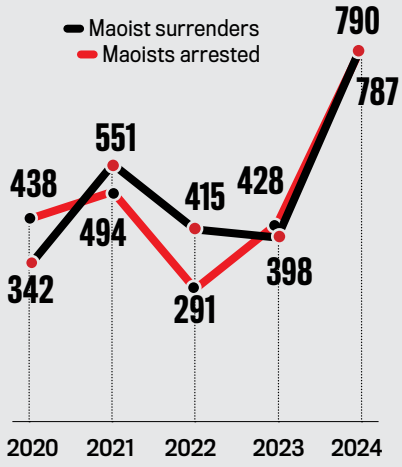


BREAK ACTION IG Pattilingam (centre) with recovered arms after an encounter near Lohagaon, Sep. 3

"Our objective is to dismantle the Maoist leadership. Their ability to perpetuate violence must end"

SUNDARRAJ PATTILINGAM
IG, Bastar

SYSTEMATIC ATTRITION



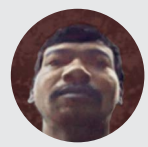
MOST WANTED



Basavaraju
Gen. secretary, CPI (Maoist)
Rs 1 crore reward



Mupalla Laxman Rao aka Ganpati
Rs 1 crore



Madvi Hidma
Rs 40 lakh

ability to perpetuate violence to end," he says. As for dismantling the Maoist leadership, the top prize for the forces is Basavaraju, the CPI (Maoist) general secretary who carries a reward of Rs 1 crore on his head. Then there is Devji, head of the central military commission, and three other politburo members, Mupalla Laxman Rao aka Ganpati, Mallojula Venugopal alias Vivek and Mishir Besra alias Bhaskar, who also carry a similar reward. Other than these top figures, there are 18 members of the central commission, each carrying a reward of Rs 40 lakh. Word is that Hidma has been promoted, and is the 18th member.

Police sources say operational successes in the past year have brought down the number of hardcore fighters in the Maoist ranks in Bastar to around 600, down from 1,400 three years ago. The attrition is not just due to encounter deaths, many have also surrendered *(see box)* or have been arrested. The large number of casualties has also stymied fresh recruitments.

DOUBLING DOWN

A big part of the successes is because field commanders now are more willing to take what security experts call a 'whatever the cost' approach. The government has green-lighted such a 'protocol' so as to clear Maoist insurgency from the land. "We get a lot of actionable intelligence, but if the operation commander feels he/she will not be protected by the establishment if collateral deaths occur, they avoid giving a go-ahead. This buffer to operate has now gone up," says a police officer in Bastar.

Another strategy deployed this year is to overwhelm the Maoists with numbers during operations. Most planned big operations have seen the participation of at least 1,000 security personnel this year. Maoist leaders camping in the forests have cordons around them, with the outermost one, manned by the 'jan militia' members who engage with the security forces, allowing the leaders to escape. To counter this, the forces are deploying cordons of their own around encounter sites, explains a police officer. Force availability has gone up with DRG and the Bastar Fighters, made up of local recruits, having a strength of around 5,000 personnel together in Bastar. The District Strike Force, a formation of ex-Salwa Judum recruits, are also available, besides the CAPF. "As a strategy, the forces vastly outnumber the Maoists during operations and are much better equipped. This is producing results," says a police officer in Bastar. Meanwhile, talk on the streets of Bastar is over why the government is moving with such alacrity to secure the area. The name of an industrial house now synonymous with every business, including mining, often springs up as the beneficiary of this clean-up.

There's also the issue of collateral damage. As operations intensify in Bastar, there are reports of civilian victims in cross-firing and 'encounter' deaths. Social activists list 19 operations in 2024 where innocents were killed. "At least 10 children under 14 have died," says Chhattisgarh-based journalist Raunak Shivharey.

But those concerns are dwarfed as the forces focus on the big picture now. Back in Dantewada, a night and day later, the DRG team returns to their lines, this time with no success. The rucksacks are emptied and the unused body bags go back to the store. Some 20 per cent of the DRG ranks are surrendered Maoists, but it is essentially made up of recruits from among the tribals of Bastar. One thing is sure, whenever the body bags come of use, it will contain the remains of a local tribal, whether from the DRG or from the ranks of the Maoists. ■